Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

James

James 1:1

- James: See “James, Brother of Jesus” Profile.
- By calling his readers the twelve tribes, James connects Christianity to the history of Israel. The exile to Babylon scattered the twelve tribes. But Jewish interpreters hoped God would reunite them (see Psalms of Solomon 17:26–28; Testament of Benjamin 9:2; compare Ezekiel 37:15–28; Matthew 19:28). Christ has spiritually ended Israel’s exile and reunited the tribes.
- the Dispersion (Greek diaspora): Jews scattered abroad were living outside Palestine (John 7:35; Acts 2:5; 8:1; 11:19).
- Greetings (Greek chairein): This was a common greeting in first-century Greek letters and in personal interactions (Acts 15:23; 23:26; Matthew 26:49; Luke 1:28).

James 1:2

- My brothers: Refer to study note on 2:1.
- James uses a wordplay. The Greek word for “joy” (chara) sounds similar to the Greek word for “greetings” that he used at the beginning of his letter in 1:1. This wordplay helps connect the opening greeting with his encouragement to find joy even during difficult times.

James 1:2–4

Enduring challenges and temptations is a common theme (1:12–15; 5:7–12). Not enduring these challenges is like a person who “wander[s] from the truth” and requires someone to “save his soul from death” (5:19–20).

James 1:5–8

James introduces wisdom as a common theme (compare 3:13–18).

James 1:6

without doubting, because he who doubts: The Greek is often translated “Do not doubt, for a person who doubts,” but it means someone torn between loyalty to God and the world (see 1:8).

James 1:8

He is a double-minded man: James might have created the Greek word used here. He emphasizes the importance of trusting only in God.

James 1:9

should exult: In the New Testament, boasting is often seen as negative (3:14; 4:16; Ephesians 2:9). But here it refers to being proud of what God has done (James 2:5; Romans 15:18; 1 Corinthians 1:31; Galatians 6:14).

James 1:9–11

James writes often about poverty and wealth in his letter (compare chapter 2; 4:13–5:11). When James talks about poor believers, he does not promise that they will become rich in this life. Instead, he teaches that God will reverse their situation in heaven.

James 1:10

James uses irony when he describes the terrible fate waiting for ungodly rich people. These are wealthy people who make themselves powerful by mistreating those who are poor and unable to protect themselves (see 2:6–8; 5:1–6).

James 1:12

is the man who perseveres under trial (see 1:22–25; 2:5; Deuteronomy 7:9; 1 John 5:2).

James 1:12–27

James discusses three topics from 1:2–11 and adds new insights to each. External challenges (in 1:2–4) become internal temptations (in 1:11–18). The need for wisdom (in 1:5–8) connects to controlling angry speech (in 1:19–21). Poverty and wealth relate to acting on God’s word (1:22–25). This section then summarizes these ideas (1:26–27).

James 1:13

James is using diatribe, an old Greek rhetorical method where an imaginary opponent gives a different opinion. This lets him express and quickly counter the possible objections of the reader (also in 2:3, 16, 18; 4:13).

James 1:14

Desires can work like hooks used for fishing or traps set up for hunting. These desires tempt (or lure) us to do wrong things and pull us away from being faithful to God.

James 1:15

Then after desire has conceived, it gives birth to sin: James describes sin as if it were a baby. If this “baby” sin becomes mature, it results in death. This

spiritual death stands in direct opposition to "crown of life" (1:12).

James 1:17

God is the Father of the heavenly lights (see footnote). This is because he created everything in the sky (Genesis 1:3, 14–17). Unlike the moving lights in the sky, God never changes or casts a shifting shadow.

James 1:18

- The word of truth is the good news about Jesus (1:21–23; 1 Peter 1:23–25).
- give us birth: The image of a mother giving birth shows the full extent of God's parental love for his children (compare Luke 13:34; John 1:13; 3:3–8; 1 Peter 1:23).
- a kind of firstfruits (compare Exodus 23:16; Leviticus 23:9–14; 1 Corinthians 15:20; Colossians 1:18): Christians are examples of the ultimate restoration of all creation (Romans 8:20–22).

James 1:21

- get rid (literally putting off) of all moral filth (compare Ephesians 4:22; 1 Peter 2:1).
- the word planted in you, which can save your souls: James emphasizes that Christians should respond to a word God has placed within us. This fulfills Jeremiah 31:31–34.
- The sould refers to the whole person (also in James 5:20; see Genesis 2:7; 1 Peter 3:20).

James 1:22

Reading the scriptures was an important part of worship (Luke 4:16–17; Acts 13:13–16; Colossians 4:16; 1 Timothy 4:13). Most people could not read and there were very few copies available. So, they listened to the scriptures being read aloud during public worship.

James 1:22–23

In several parts of the letter, James seems to ponder the teachings of Jesus. These verses show the teachings of Jesus (Matthew 7:24, 26; Luke 6:46, 49).

James 1:24

forgets what he looks like: The issue is not the poor quality of an ancient mirror, but the viewer's lack of attention (see Matthew 7:24–27).

James 1:25

God's word gives us new life and salvation (1:18, 21). But it also requires us to follow its teachings (1:22–25).

James 1:26–27

- bridle his tongue: James uses this image to show that controlling your tongue reflects the condition of your heart and direction of life (compare 3:1–13).
- orphans and widows were the most vulnerable people in ancient society. They relied on others for support because the husband and father provided economic help and social connections (Exodus 22:22–24; Deuteronomy 10:18). God calls Christians to especially care for those who are helpless (compare 1 Timothy 5:3–16).
- In James, the world is hostile to God (compare James 3:15; 4:4; Romans 12:2; 1 John 2:15–17).

James 2:1

- My brothers (Greek adelphoi): The Greek word here means members of the same family. In this case, it refers to fellow Christians of either sex. James often starts a new section with this loving greeting, seeking their loyal response (1:2, 16; 2:14; 3:1; 5:7, 19).
- James contrasts our glorious Lord Jesus Christ with the glory of a well-dressed man (2:2). The glory of Christ includes his resurrection from the dead, his exalted position in heaven, and his future return to earth.

James 2:1–4

James uses a realistic example to explain why we must not favor the rich.

James 2:2

- your meeting (literally your synagogue): This term refers to the gathering of people, not the building where they met.
- The rich wear fancy clothes and expensive jewelry, while the poor wear shabby clothes. This shows the difference in their socioeconomic status.

James 2:3–4

People often focus on wealthy individuals due to their social status, political power, and potential generosity. By serving and publicly honoring the wealthy, the church could receive economic benefits. James warns that this favoritism shows evil motives, creating a divide between loyalty to God and a desire for worldly wealth (1:6; 4:4).

James 2:5

- Listen: James uses this rhetorical device for emphasis (see Deuteronomy 6:3; Amos 3:1; Matt 13:18; Acts 15:13). James presents his argument against favoring the rich.

- Has not God chosen the poor: God cares deeply for the poor, as shown in the Old Testament (Exodus 23:11; 1 Samuel 2:8; Psalm 12:5). It is also shown in the ministries of Jesus and Paul (Luke 4:18; 6:20; 1 Corinthians 1:26–28). The Jerusalem church, led by James, also emphasized this concern (Galatians 2:9–10).
- inherit the kingdom: The kingdom of God was central to the teachings of Jesus (Matthew 12:8; Mark 1:15; Luke 17:21). Christ already rules from the right hand of the Father, but his kingdom will be fully realized when he returns in his glory (Matthew 25:31, 34; 1 Corinthians 15:24–28).

James 2:7

Name by which you have been called (literally name spoken over you): The name is Jesus Christ (2:1). It is a sign of ownership, declared at the time of conversion and baptism.

James 2:8

- Christians should obey (literally fulfill) the royal law, just as Jesus fulfilled the law by coming and teaching ((Matthew 5:17; 22:34–40).
- It is the royal law because it belongs to the kingdom and our glorious Lord (King) gave it (James 2:5).
- in Scripture: James shifts from a general mention of the law to a specific commandment from "the holiness code" (Leviticus 19). It explains how we show our love for God through relationships with others (see Leviticus 19:18; Deuteronomy 6:5).
- Love your neighbor as yourself: This quote from Leviticus 19:18 means treating your neighbor as you would treat yourself.

James 2:8–13

James uses the Bible to argue against the common practice of favoring wealthy and powerful people.

James 2:9

Favoritism opposes the command to love your neighbor (2:8).

James 2:12

The law that gives freedom from the power of sin (see 1:25 and corresponding study note). It promotes endurance and grow towards perfection (1:3–4).

James 2:13

James ends this section (2:1–13) by linking God's mercy with human mercy (see also Matthew 6:14–15; Ephesians 4:32).

James 2:14

If someone claims to have faith: James writes to Christians to urge them to actions that come from true faith. Paul teaches the same thing (see, for example, Galatians 5:6). But he often criticizes those who rely on actions to define their relationship with God (Romans 3:20, 28; 4:3–5; Galatians 2:16; 3:1–14).

James 2:14–26

James explains why Christians should care about how God will judge their actions (2:12–13): Good deeds must accompany true faith (see 1:22–25).

James 2:15–16

- Suppose: In 2:2–4, James gives an example of "faith" that is useless.
- without clothes and daily food: In first-century Palestine and the Roman world, many people who were poor lacked basic needs.
- stay warm and well-fed: This probably assumes that God will provide for the poor. The speaker might think that believing it will happen is enough. But without action, it is just an empty hope.

James 2:18–19

- James shows that believing something is true without acting on it is pointless.
- But someone will say: James offers another diatribe (see study note on 1:13). He introduces a possible argument someone might make. The imaginary person argues that different Christians might have different gifts—one person might have the gift of faith while another has the gift of works (see 1 Corinthians 12:7–9).

James 2:19

- that God is one (or there is one God): This is the core belief of Israel's faith (see Deuteronomy 6:4).
- the demons believe: They know there is one God, and he is their enemy (Mark 1:24).

James 2:20–26

James shows through Scripture that true faith is shown through actions.

James 2:22

This verse explains 2:21 so that people will not understand it. Abraham was not justified (made right with God) by his actions alone. Instead, his faith and actions worked together to show his complete commitment to God (see Genesis 12:1–4; 18:1–27).

James 2:23

- the Scripture was fulfilled: James saw the offering of Isaac in Genesis 22 as fulfilling the pledge of the faith of Abraham and the declaration of God that Abraham was righteous (quoted from Genesis 15:6).
- he was called a friend of God: James emphasizes that faith is a relationship of complete loyalty (James 1:5–8; 4:4; John 15:15).

James 2:24

Not by faith alone: This means that true faith is not like demons who simply believe something is true (2:19). But it is through a belief that leads to generous actions like God himself does (1:17). Some think this teaching contradicts Paul, but it does not. Paul does not oppose good deeds, but he warns against seeking forgiveness of sins through them (Romans 3:28; Galatians 2:16). Paul understands that it is necessary for true faith to leads to love and generosity (Galatians 5:6). In a similar way, James knows that a commitment to God comes from true faith and good deeds come only from true faith (James 2:18, 26).

James 2:25

James uses Rahab the prostitute (see Joshua 2:1) as an example that good deeds must accompany true faith. She declared her belief that the Lord God of Israel was the only God (Joshua 2:9–11). Her actions completed her faith. This happened when she hosted and helped the Israelite spies escape (Joshua 2:1–6; 6:25; Hebrews 11:31).

James 2:26

Good works are as essential to faith as breathing is to a body (Genesis 2:7). We need both together.

James 3:1

In the early church, becoming a teacher was one way to improve social status (1 Corinthians 12:28; Ephesians 4:11; 1 Timothy 5:17; compare Acts 5:34). This honor was especially valuable for Christians who were often treated poorly as outsiders in their society (James 2:6–7). However, James warns about rushing to become a teacher without understanding the responsibility. Teachers have great influence through their words. Their speech can either help build up the church community or cause serious harm to it. This shows the power of human speech, which is a major theme in James's letter.

James 3:2

We all: The main concern of James is how the speech of church members affects their relationships with others (3:9–10, 14; 4:1–3).

James 3:6

- a world of wickedness: The tongue (our speech) acts as an agent of the whole unrighteous world that opposes God (1:27; 4:4).
- by hell: The Greek word Gehenna refers to the place of eternal punishment (Matthew 5:22, 30; 23:15). Hades is the place of the dead (Luke 16:23; Acts 2:31). Mentioning hell points to the devil as the ultimate source of evil speech (James 4:7; Matt 5:22; John 8:44).

James 3:8

- No man can tame the tongue: The tongue has a remarkable ability to do harm. If hell motivates its evil, humans effort alone cannot control it (3:6).
- full of deadly poison: This might refer to the serpent in the garden of Eden (Genesis 3:1). The Scriptures identify the serpent with the devil (Revelation 20:2).

James 3:9

Bless ... curse: Blessing our Lord and Father is the best use of our tongues. Cursing people, who are made in God's image, is one of the worst. It indirectly curses God himself (Genesis 1:26–27; 9:6).

James 3:11

Some springs, especially in the upper sources of the Jordan River, produced both fresh water and salt water. These salty springs could not support a town. Similarly, if a person's speech mixes bad with good, it will not help the community.

James 3:13

Who is wise and understanding among you: The wisdom from God is not only skill of intelligence or a collection of facts (1:5). It is practical insight and spiritual understanding that shows in moral behavior, as described in 3:17–18 (see also Job 28:28; Proverbs 1:2–4; 2:10–15).

James 3:14

Wisdom has no association with jealousy and selfish ambition. We can only receive God's true word through humility (1:18, 21).

James 3:15

Earthly wisdom is not part of God's good creation. It is the opposite of heavenly wisdom because it leaves out God. It is unspiritual because it does not acknowledge or respond to God's Spirit (1 Corinthians 2:14; Jude 1:19). It is demonic because it comes from the devil, who is the ultimate source of this wisdom that destroys (James 3:6; 4:6; 1 Timothy 4:1).

James 3:18

James uses a farming image to highlight the benefits of living by wisdom from above. Those who sow in peace in relationships will reap a rich harvest of righteousness in those relationships (see Matthew 5:9).

James 4:1

Conflicts and quarrels (literally wars and battles): James uses military imagery to show that their own evil desires cause the battles among church members. These desires are at war within themselves. James uses the Greek word for passions again in 4:3 (translated as "pleasures"). This frames the entire paragraph and show the source of conflict and unanswered prayer (Luke 8:14; Titus 3:3).

James 4:2

you kill and covet: Killing was the extreme but logical result of their greedy mindset. Some of James's readers might have joined the Jewish Zealot movement and committed murder for their cause. Hostile attitudes and violent methods do not bring satisfaction —you cannot achieve your goals with them.

James 4:4

- You adulteresses: James uses this prophetic imagery to challenge his audience (see, for example, Jeremiah 3:6; Hosea 3:1). They were seeking what friendship with the world could offer them. This included:
- social acceptance (James 2:1–4),
- prestige (3:1), or
- wealth (4:13).

Divided loyalty toward God is like being unfaithful to a spouse (4:8).

- In ancient times, "friend" was a title for special and exclusive relationships (Luke 23:12, Herod and Pilate). John 19:12 speaks of Pilate as "friend of Caesar" (see also 1 Maccabees 2:18; 6:28). The Scriptures call Moses and Abraham "friend of God" (Exodus 33:11; James 2:23; 2 Chronicles 20:7; Isaiah 41:8; compare John 15:15).
- The world consists of society that opposes God and his kingdom. The world follows earthly wisdom, not heavenly wisdom (James 3:15–17). Evil desires, fighting, and killing mark the world (4:2–3).

James 4:4–10

James explains the causes of conflict among people: love for the world, divided loyalty, and arrogant criticism (4:11–12). He gives instructions that will fix these problems and lead to peace.

James 4:5

the Scripture says: James summarizes one of the messages of Scripture. The spirit God placed in us should be faithful to him.

James 4:7

Resist the devil: See also Ephesians 6:11; 1 Peter 5:8.

James 4:8

- Draw near to God: This means building a friendship (2:23) and being loyal (1:6–8).
- cleanse your hands ... purify your hearts: The applies the biblical idea of ceremonial cleansing to purifying your intentions (compare Mark 7:1–23).

James 4:10

God honors those who humble themselves before him, replacing the shame of their persecution and oppression (James 2:6–7).

James 4:11

do not slander one another: This appeal for peace among Christians means they must not speak badly about one another. Speaking badly about a neighbor is like speaking badly about God's law. This is because the law forbids slander and requires loving your neighbor (2:8; Leviticus 19:16–18; Matthew 7:1–5).

James 4:11–12

These verses discuss the teaching in Matthew 7:1 and Luke 6:37 (see study note on James 1:22–23).

James 4:13–16

Traveling merchants relied on their own determination to overcome poverty and low social status. James encourages acknowledging God's providence. He also warns against making arrogant plans beyond one's control.

James 4:15

The Lord controls life and death (Deuteronomy 32:39; 1 Samuel 2:6; Matthew 10:28).

James 4:16

Christians can proudly share what God has done (1:9–10). But they should not brag about their own plans. When people make plans without considering God's will, they act as if they control their own future. These kinds of plans assume that God has no authority over people's lives.

James 4:17

who knows the right thing to do: this verse is probably a saying that James thought his audience would know. Its origin is unknown, but it aligns with Scripture teachings (compare Deuteronomy 24:15; Proverbs 3:27–28; Matthew 25:41–46; Luke 12:47).

James 5:1–6

This section criticizes wealthy people for being greedy and proud mistreatment of the poor (Leviticus 19:13). James warns them to change their ways while they still can. If they do not, they will encounter frightening consequences on judgment day.

James 5:2

The wealth and fine clothes are so excessive that they decay from not being used. Their ruin is a sign of the anticipated judgment.

James 5:3

Material wealth, like gold and silver, is worthless when facing God's judgment. It will actually speak against them because they obtained it unfairly and used it wickedly (5:4, 5–6).

James 5:4

- These wealthy individuals were landowners who exploited their workers (5:1). They are like those in 2:6 who oppressed and took Christians to court. These rich people exploited the day laborers who harvested their fields.
- cries ... have reached the ears of the Lord: God hears the prayers of the oppressed (see Deuteronomy 24:14–15). Even while the laborers are still suffering, the Lord has heard them (see Exodus 3:7).
- the Lord of Hosts (1 Samuel 17:45; Psalm 103:20–21; Romans 9:29): This title emphasizes God's power to act when the oppressed cannot.

James 5:6

Murdered the righteous (or killed the Righteous One): Here, this phrase probably refers to innocent people like the oppressed workers mentioned in this paragraph, rather than to Jesus (compare Acts 3:14; 7:52).

James 5:7–8

Be patient: This is the ultimate solution for the poor enduring economic struggles and unfair treatment by the wicked people who are rich (5:1–6; see 2:6–7). People may treat the poor as insignificant and oppress them. Yet, they should not give up or retaliate against their oppressors. When the Lord returns, the faithful will receive their final reward (Isaiah 40:10; Luke 6:20–35; 1 Corinthians 15:23; 1 Peter 1:17; 5:4; Revelation 22:12).

James 5:9

the Judge is standing at the door! Christ's arrival is close.

James 5:10

This verse comments on Matthew 5:11 and Luke 6:23 (see study note on James 1:22–23).

James 5:11

Job showed great endurance by staying faithful to God during his hardships (Job 1:20–21; 2:9–10). He was faithful even though he complained (Job 3:1–26; 12:1–3; 16:1–3).

James 5:12

do not swear: The churches were having serious arguments (4:1–3, 11–12), so James advised them to avoid dishonest oaths by not using any oaths at all (Matt 5:33–37). Swearing an oath in the Lord's name meant asking God to enforce it (Genesis 31:53; 1 Kings 8:31–32). People swore by heaven or earth. They either pretended to be respectful while avoiding speaking God's name or used tricky words to deceive (Matthew 23:16–22). Peter used an oath dishonestly (Matthew 26:71–73). But Paul used one to support his claims (Romans 1:9; 2 Corinthians 1:23). This indicates that the rule against oaths is not absolute.

James 5:14

- The church elders took care of a local group of Christians. People chose them for their age and leadership skills (Acts 14:23; 20:17, 28; 1 Peter 5:1–4; compare 1 Timothy 3:1–7; Titus 1:5–9).
- During the early development of the church (around AD 40s), "church" meant "congregation" or "assem-

bly" (see also Matthew 18:17)(see James Book Introduction, "Date and Location of Writing").
- anoint him with oil: The practice of anointing with oil was a symbol of divine blessing and healing (Isaiah 1:6; Matthew 6:17; Mark 6:13; Luke 10:34).

James 5:15

- The prayer offered in faith will restore the one who is sick: This saying is generally true, depending on God's will. Only prayers with genuine faith will receive a positive response from the Lord. Faith for healing is a gift from God (See also Mark 9:23; John 14:13–14; 15:7, 16; 16:23–27; 1 John 3:22; 5:14–15).
- If he has sinned: James suggests that some illnesses might result from sin. It is important to confess and seek forgiveness for the sin (James 5:16; see Mark 2:3–12; John 5:14).

James 5:17

- Elijah ... prayed earnestly: See 1 Kings 17:1; 18:41–46.
- three and a half years (see 1 Kings 18:1; Luke 4:25) is an approximate time, representing half of seven, which symbolizes a period of judgment (compare Daniel 12:7; Revelation 11:2).

James 5:19–20

These verses conclude the letter as an inclusio. This means they balance with and relate to the beginning of the letter. The final section connects back to James's opening words about endurance in 1:2–4.

James 5:20

When James talks about saving "a sinner from death," he means more than just physical death. He is referring to eternal death, which is the punishment for those who turn away from the truth of the good news of Jesus Christ (see 1:12, 15; compare Hebrews 6:4–8).

James teaches that if someone has wandered from the truth, other believers should try to bring that person back to the right path. If the person who has sinned listens and turns back to God (repents), then eternal punishment will be avoided (see also Galatians 6:1; Jude 1:22–24).